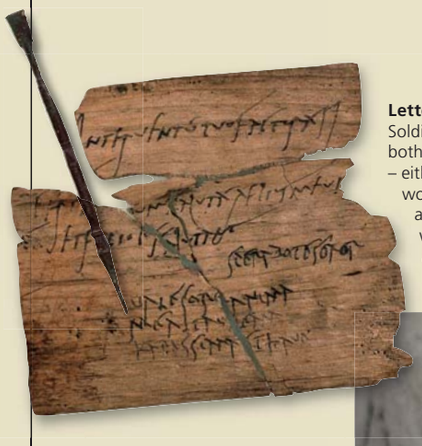
THE BARRACKS

The barrack blocks at Arbeia were built of plastered stonework outside with wattle-and-daub dividing walls inside. The auxiliary troops that were stationed there would have been divided, like legionaries, into eight-man *contubernia*, or "tent groups". Each infantry block housed five *contubernia* and each *contubernium* was allotted a cramped two-roomed suite, which also had to accommodate much of their equipment. The centurion and the lower ranking officers lived in a slightly larger suite at the end of the barracks. Cavalrymen were billeted in similar sized barracks. With 30 men and their horses housed in each block, conditions were even less enviable than those of the infantry.





Exterior and interior of the barracks
There were few windows to let in light or fresh air, but the roof tiles were pierced intermittently with ventilators. The internal walls at Arbeia were made of wattle-and-daub *(left)*, a form of inexpensive plasterwork.



Letter and stylus
Soldiers wrote letters – both official and personal – either in ink on thin wooden panels or using a stylus to write on wax. The letters were about the size of a large postcard.



Dormitory
The ordinary soldiers of a Roman *contubernium* would have spent most of their time in the larger of their two rooms. It was here that they slept – either under woollen blankets on beds like these or simply on mattresses on the floor.

Sanitation
Many forts had a bathhouse outside the fort for the troops, while the commanding officer's family had their own baths in the house. This communal latrine near Hadrian's Wall makes up for lack of privacy with high-quality plumbing.

